

YEAR-ROUND INTEREST

When choosing plants for your garden, try to include a selection of feature trees and shrubs that have more than one season of interest. There is a wide range of trees and shrubs, both deciduous and evergreen, that perform for most of the year.



Cornus alba

A deciduous shrub with white flowers in late spring, as well as striking red shoots in winter. The leaves turn red or orange in fall.



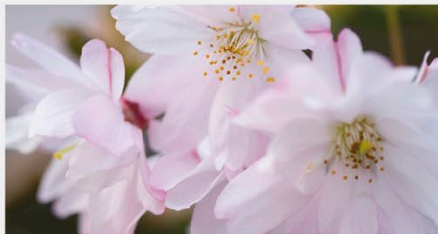
***Mahonia x media* 'Charity'**

Mahonias have shiny, evergreen foliage, plus yellow flowers and purple or black fruits. 'Charity' has scented yellow flowers in winter.



Nandina domestica

The leaves of this evergreen shrub have red tints in spring and fall. Small, white summer flowers are followed by bright red berries.



***Prunus x subhirtella* 'Autumnalis Rosea'**

This cherry tree has tiny, pale pink flowers that appear in winter. The green leaves are bronze when young, turning golden-yellow in fall.

tones in a shady woodland area at the far end of the garden. Another option is to use the same bed or border to change in mood as the seasons progress, with bright daffodils and tulips in spring, followed by herbaceous summer planting in blues, purples, pale pinks, and whites, and then fiery foliage color in the fall.

Single-color-themed borders, whether white and cream or varying shades of yellow, look highly sophisticated and produce a satisfying cohesion. The restricted plant choices can also make designing a little easier.

You can also use color to draw attention to a particular feature or planting area. To produce this effect, ensure your plants contrast with the surroundings to increase their visibility. For example, a single, bright orange plant against a recessive background color, such as green or blue, will create an effective accent. Planting schemes that combine swaths of warm and cool colors also work well, with the cooler colors providing a foil for the hot hues.

You can also exploit the way in which colors can alter perceptions of distance. For instance, bright reds and oranges planted at the end of a garden have a foreshortening effect, making the garden appear shorter, while pale colors can make the garden seem longer.

The effects of light and shade

The way that we perceive color is influenced by the amount of light it receives. Sunny borders will make colors appear bolder and brighter, while shady areas enhance more subtle colors and white. The colors of plants can therefore change depending on their location, the degree of shade cast on them, and on the time of day. For example, pale colors that produce beautiful effects in the early morning or evening may be bleached out by strong midday sunlight. Bear this in mind if you tend to use your garden at a particular time of day. If you work and sit outside mainly in the evenings, choose white and pale flowers that take on a luminous quality in the fading light.

Choose colors that produce the best effects for different areas of the garden. Plant reds, oranges, bright pinks, and yellows in sunny spaces, as they will look muddy in the shade. Nature often makes this choice for you, as many hot-hued flowers need a sunny spot to thrive. Woodland plants, on the other hand, tend to produce flowers in whites, pastel shades of yellow, pink and purple, and blues, all of which show up better in shade.

Creating a succession of year-round color

When selecting plants, try to include a range that flower or are at their peak at different times of the year to sustain the interest. This is particularly important in small gardens, where the planting is on view year-round.

Consider the merits of each plant, including its size, habit, leaf shape, texture and color, flowers, and fruit. For a prolonged display, focus on foliage, either evergreen for constant color, or deciduous, which in most cases endures from spring to fall. This leafy mix provides a backdrop for the succession of flowers that appear. When choosing flowering plants, remember that many have beautiful seedheads, including love-in-a-mist (*Nigella*), poppies, hylotelephiums, sedums, and eryngiums, that provide two seasons of interest. Also use containers to add an extra dimension to borders and patio displays; one large planter can be used for four different seasonal displays.

Spring

When spring makes a welcome appearance, the garden is soon awash with color. Some is provided by spring-flowering trees and shrubs, such as amelanchiers, ornamental cherries, apples, plums, and almonds (*Prunus*), magnolias, some viburnums, camellias, and forsythias, as well as a host of tough rock



Spring match

Create a balanced display in your borders with a mixture of tulips, such as 'Bleu Aimable', scented biennial wallflowers (*Erysimum*), and dainty violas providing color in the foreground.